zD'var Torah: Parshat Chayei Sarah

The Power of the Imahot: Nature, Nurture, and Rising Above

Introduction: It's Not Just About the Fathers

In the last several weeks, we've been talking about zechut Avot, the power and impact of the fathers. But truth be told, it's not just all about the fathers. As we discussed in last week's parsha when we looked at the concept of three, it's a husband, a wife, and Hashem together that make a child and bring this world into focus. The partnership of these three brings blessing, continuity, and purpose to the world.

As we refocus on this week's parsha, Chayei Sarah, we see zechut Imahot, the power and the zechut that we gain from the mothers. Their influence reverberates not only through our history, but in every Jewish home and every Jewish heart. Another concept we see in this week's parsha, and in future parshiot as well, is a deeper understanding of something that goes back and forth in our world today: the concept of nature versus nurture.

Chayei Sarah: A Life of Completion

At the very beginning of the parsha, we encounter remarkable words:

"And the life of Sarah was one hundred years and twenty years and seven years; the years of Sarah's life."
ויהיו חיי שרה מאה שנה ועשרים שנה ושבע שנים שני חיי שרה (Bereishit 23:1)

The way the verse is structured is unusual. Rashi explains that the Torah breaks down Sarah's age into separate segments to teach us something profound: at a hundred she was as free of sin as at twenty (when one reaches the age of responsibility), and at twenty she was as beautiful as at seven. She lived a complete life, a life of shleimut. The repetition of "the years of Sarah's life" teaches us that all her years were equally good.

The Midrash Tanchuma (Vayeira 23) relates that among the factors that brought about Sarah's death was news of the Akeidah. The Satan came to Sarah disguised as Yitzchak and told her that Avraham had taken him to a mountain, built an altar, arranged wood, bound him, and was

about to slaughter him when Hashem's angel intervened. Upon hearing this, Sarah's soul departed from her.

But I want to offer a different perspective here, one rooted in Chassidic teachings. There's a profound teaching brought down by the Baal Shem Tov and other teachers: when a person completes their tafkid in this world, when they've fulfilled the specific mitzvah for which they were created, their soul may return to its Source if it no longer needs to remain in this world.

This concept goes back to being shutaf with Hashem, that we are partners with Him in creation. That's our side of the partnership: creating that which He needs us to create in this world. Not to say He couldn't do it on His own, but this is the design, the goal, the way He built us and built the world.

Sarah's tafkid, her mission, was Yitzchak. Not just to give birth to him, but to ensure he was brought up in such a way that he himself would have the strength and spiritual preparation to fulfill his role in the Akeidah. Consider this: he was 37 years old when the Akedat Yitzchak happened. A 37 year old intelligent man is not going to arbitrarily lie down on a sacrificial altar with his father holding a knife over him. Something profound was infused in him by both parents to bring about his ability to follow through with this. That chinuch, that spiritual education, came in large part from his mother, Sarah.

Once Sarah's mission was fulfilled, once she had raised Yitzchak to this level of faith and commitment, her neshamah had completed its work in this world. At this stage, we can understand her passing not as tragedy alone, but as the natural completion of a life lived with perfect shleimut.

The Mother's Role in Chinuch: The Foundation of Jewish Education

The foundation of Jewish chinuch comes from the mother. This is explicit in our tradition. The Midrash in Shemot Rabbah (28:2) discusses why Hashem instructed Moshe to speak first to the women when giving the Torah, explaining: "Why were the women first? Because they are zealous in mitzvot. Alternatively, so that they could teach their children Torah."

The mother's sacred role includes teaching the children the Shema. The very first learning of the Shema typically comes from the mother. Think about what the Shema represents: it is the ability to say, "I am nothing without Hashem." It's an ultimate statement of bittul, of nullifying oneself before the Creator. This is the deepest foundation a mother can give, teaching a child from the earliest age that we exist in partnership with Hashem, that everything we have and everything we are comes from Him.

We can see the impact, the tafkid, the sacred work of mothers coming to fruition through generations. This is not just about biological motherhood, but about the spiritual role that Jewish women play in ensuring the continuity of our people and our Torah.

Rivka: The Return of Sarah's Miracles

The parsha continues with a beautiful transition. When Rivka came from her home and was brought by Yitzchak to Sarah's tent, something extraordinary happened. Rashi (Bereishit 24:67) explains that when Rivka entered that sacred space, the miracles that had characterized Sarah's tent during her lifetime returned.

What were these miracles? The Midrash (Bereishit Rabbah 60:16) teaches that three miraculous signs accompanied Sarah's righteousness. First, the Shabbat candles she lit would burn from one Shabbat eve to the next Shabbat eve. Second, there was a blessing in her dough that ensured it never spoiled. Third, a cloud of glory hovered over her tent, a sign of the Divine Presence dwelling there.

These three miracles correspond to the three primary mitzvot associated with Jewish women: lighting Shabbat candles (ner), separating challah (challah), and maintaining family purity (niddah). Through these mitzvot, a Jewish woman creates a dwelling place for the Shechinah, bringing Hashem's presence into the home in a tangible way.

The teaching also tells us that a husband cannot be fully connected to his wife while his mother is still present in the same way. This is not to suggest a mother's influence is negative, but rather to acknowledge that a mother's presence continues to shape her son's life even after he marries. There comes a time when a man must fully cleave to his wife and establish an independent household. Only when Rivka fully stepped into Sarah's role could Yitzchak be comforted for the loss of his mother, because he saw that the legacy would continue.

Nature versus Nurture: Breaking the Mold

These concepts go hand in hand with understanding how we grow beyond our circumstances. Let's step back and trace this theme through our forefathers.

Adam HaRishon had no one to nurture him, only the nature that Hashem created within him. Yet even that pure nature, combined with free will, led him down a path that brought death into the world.

Moving forward to Avraham Avinu. Nurture would have dictated that he follow his father Terach into idol worship. His father manufactured and sold idols, so Avraham was literally raised in a house and business built on avodah zarah. He could have followed his father either into belief in false gods or into the cynical business of selling them. Yet Avraham broke free entirely. He used his bechirah, his free will, to recognize truth and forge a new path. This teaches us that while nature and nurture may influence us profoundly, they do not determine our destiny. The bechirah given to Adam and passed down to all humanity allows us to transcend our circumstances.

Rivka: A Rose Among Thorns

We see this perhaps most dramatically in Rivka. She was raised by Betuel and Lavan, not exactly paragons of virtue. The mefarshim explain that these were people so corrupt that they

tried to poison Eliezer while he was in their home, hoping to steal his wealth. Her mother Milcah went along with their schemes. These were people characterized by deception, greed, and violence.

Even more disturbing, Chazal teach that when Rivka chose to leave with Eliezer to marry Yitzchak, she wanted to depart with great haste because the region where she lived was known as a place where children were violated. It was spiritually and morally dangerous in the extreme.

On one level, we might say it is only natural to want to escape such a place. But consider the nurture aspect. This was her reality, her normal. We see with Lot that when he tried to warn his sons in law about the impending destruction of Sodom, they thought he was joking. They could not conceive of leaving because the evil had become normalized to them. Many people do not recognize they need to leave toxic environments because those environments have shaped their entire worldview.

But Rivka's personal awareness, even at a young age, told her clearly that this is a bad place to be and these are not the values she wants to live by.

Questions for Reflection

How am I uplifting the Imahot in my world? Whether they are mothers now, will become mothers, or are not able to become mothers (chas v'shalom), how am I ensuring that the women around me are treated with respect and dignity?

Second: How am I breaking out of my own patterns of nature and nurture to become an even more exemplary human being? Even if we were raised in righteous homes, we can always grow further. How can I push beyond what was given to me to reach higher levels of holiness and service?

Third: How am I enabling those around me to grow beyond their seeming limitations? How can I uplift others, like Eliezer, helping them rise above their circumstances and step into their mission in the eyes of Hashem?

Have a wonderful, blessed Shabbat.